Introduction to Omeka S & Dublin Core

HIST 5237: Issues and Methods in Public History
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Fall 2026
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Workshop Agenda

- Introduction: what is Omeka S and what are digital archives?
- Review and discussion of digital projects built with Omeka S
- Introduction: Dublin Core metadata standard
- Demonstration: Omeka S

All materials are available here:
https://bit.ly/fa26-parr-hist5237-omekas

Introduction to Omeka

What is Omeka? (Part 1)



- Developed by the Corporation for Digital Scholarship (CDS), a non-profit started in 2009 at the Roy Rosenzweig Center for History and New Media at George Mason University.
- CDS maintains and funds a host of open access tools for researchers and cultural heritage institutions including: Zotero, Tropy, PressForward, Sourcery, and Omeka.

What is Omeka? (Part 2)

- Omeka is a **web publishing platform** for **items**, **exhibits**, and **collections**
- Designed with scholars, librarians, educators and archivists in mind, Omeka emphasizes the role of **metadata** in **archiving** and **curation**
- Omeka offers the ability to contextualize items & bring them into conversation with one another
- Omeka makes it easy to create and update metadata using **Dublin Core** standards, a general vocabulary for describing digital or physical items

Versions of Omeka

There are three different versions of Omeka, each with their own benefits for different types of audiences, institutions, and users.

Omeka.net: provides free and priced plan options, including support and hosting by Omeka (CDS).

Omeka Classic: built for individuals or educators where each site requires a different installation, including separate hosting (domain/URL).

Omeka S: built for institutions managing a sharable resource pool across multiple sites or other collections and resources.

About of Omeka S

Omeka S is a web publication system for universities, galleries, libraries, archives, and museums. It creates a local network of independently curated exhibits sharing a collaboratively built pool of items and their metadata.

Omeca S Sections

- **Sites:** Creating, editing, and managing sites, the public-facing parts of an Omeka S installation.
- **Resources**: Creating, editing, and managing the content of an installation: items, item sets, media, vocabularies, and resource templates.
- **Admin**: Access to functionality in the administrative interface varies by user role, but can include: users, jobs, assets, and settings.
- **Modules**: It then offers specific documentation for Omeka S modules created by the Omeka Team, listed in alphabetical order. It also includes glossary, searchesr, and error logging.

Group Activity: Explore and Discuss Omeka S Projects

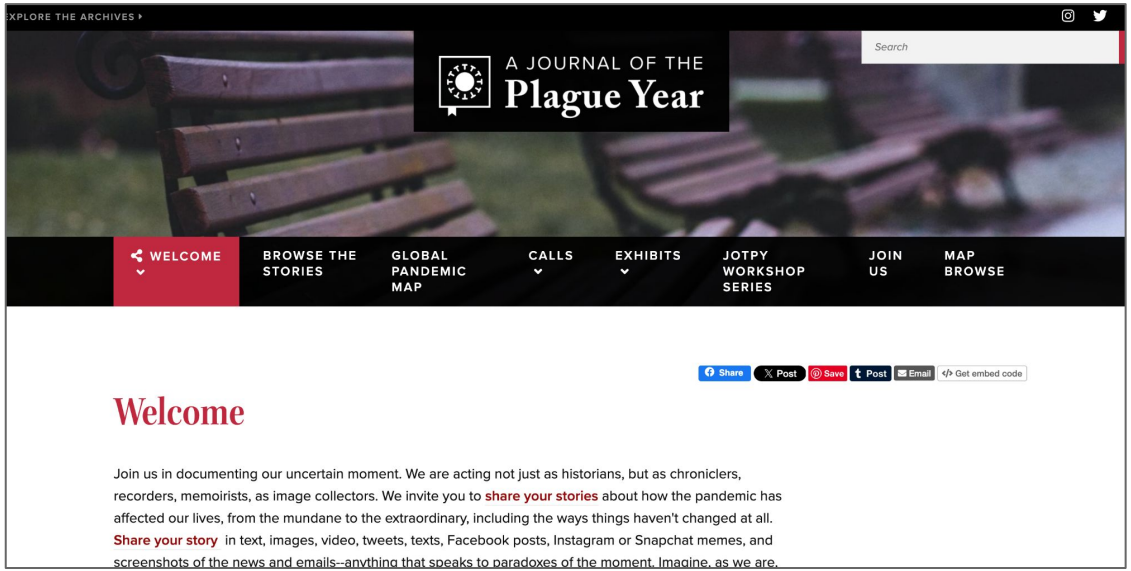
Example Omeka Projects

Many projects use Omeka S to organize, describe, and showcase archival materials. Here are a few examples:

- See the "Women and Social Movements in the 19th and 20th Centuries" Omeka S exhibit discussed by Karen Balcom and Rachel Manes
- See the "Posters of the 1848 French Revolution" Omeka S exhibit discussed by Myron Groover and Nina Sartor

A Journal of the Plague Year

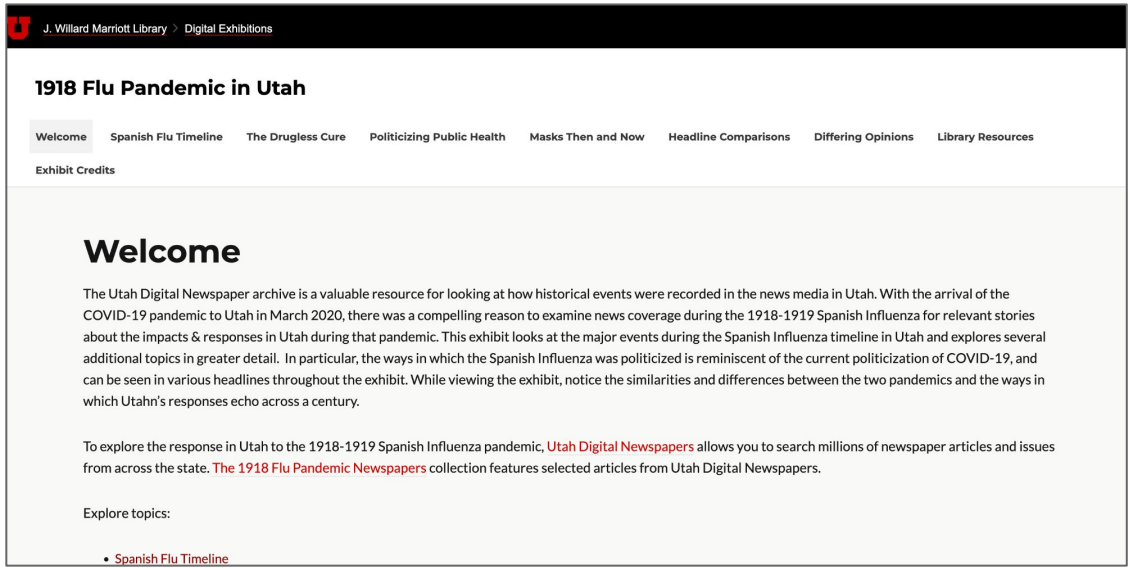
The **A Journal of the Plague Year** is an archive of COVID-19 pandemic. This is an interactive project that crowdsources stories to contribute to the archive. It utilizes interactive digital humanities methods.



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1918 Flu Pandemic in Utah

1918 Flu Pandemic in Utah is a digital newspaper archive for the Spanish Influenza. The project is interested in looks to find out more about the way the Spanish Flu was documented in the news and compare that to Covid-19.



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Discussion Questions

- What metadata fields did these projects use?
  - Are any surprising to you?
- How did the metadata fields differ across the projects?
- How did the projects' use of Omeka differ?
- Why do you think Omeka was chosen for these projects over something like WordPress or Squarespace? How might these sites look different if they were hosted on one of those platforms?

Dublin Core

Metadata Standards: Dublin Core

Metadata Standards: a shared system used by projects and institutions to structure and understand data, including principles and rules for implementing the description and categorization of data.

Dublin Core: first created in 1995, this standard includes elements to describe items in information systems and is used by many groups.

Dublin Core Specifics

- Dublin Core was created to support open cultural heritage data.
- It is designed to be simple and flexible, which has both advantages and disadvantages.
- Fields include: title, contributor, creator, date, subject, description, format, identifier, language, publisher, relation, rights, source, and type.

Dublin Core Best Practices

- All the fields are optional, so you can choose which you want to use to describe the items in your archive; be strategic about which fields you select!
- It is essential to have consistency in metadata fields across your items: both in which you select and in how you fill those in (for instance, you don't want to have "Firstname Lastname" in half your "creator" fields and "Lastname, Firstname" in the other half)

Tool Demonstration: Omeka S

Key Omeka S Terms 1

- **Items:** The records used to build an Omeka S Site. Items are shared and available to any Site in an Installation, unless explicitly excluded from sharing.
- **Item Set**: An aggregation of Items. Items can belong to any number of Item Sets.
- **Vocabularies**: A collection of published RDF metadata Classes and Properties for describing a Resource. The most-used Vocabulary is Dublin Core Terms (dcterms:).

Key Omeka S Terms 2

- **Media:** Omeka S accepts most files and file types, and can be customized to accept or reject file types of your choice. Media are only created by adding them to an item; media cannot exist independently.
- **Site**: Every site stands on its own with separate branding, browse pages, search pages, and as many exhibits as desired. Each "site" is its own exhibit.
- **Pages:** website pages on Omeka for different exhibits, complete with different formats including gallery, text, file, etc.

Access to Omeca S Sandbox

- Go to https://dev.omeka.org/omeka-s-sandbox/login
- Use this username: omekasdemo1@example.com
- Use this password: omekasdemo1

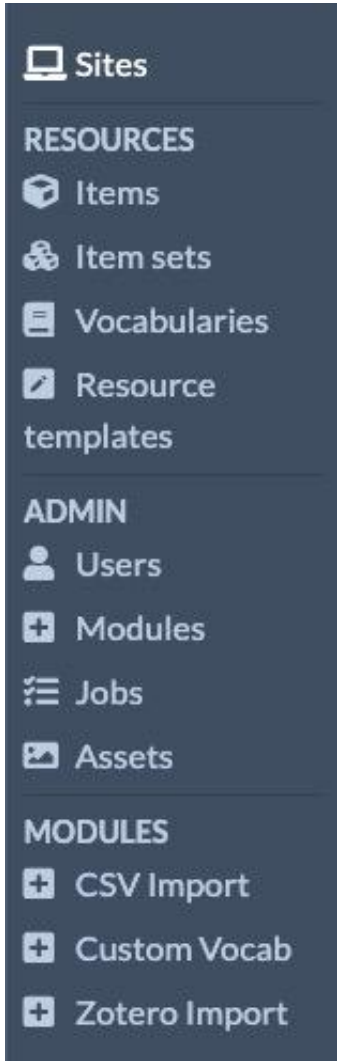
Creating Your Omeka Account

- Go to: https://www.omeka.net/signup
- Choose a trial plan
- Click on the activation link sent to your email
- Then, under “Add a Site,” enter a subdomain name (for the URL), site title, and site description.
- Once you have added your site, click ‘Manage site’ to navigate to the site’s dashboard.

Note: Once you create the site (with the trial on Omeka.net) you can't set it to private. **But** you can control whether individual items, exhibits, or pages are private.



Omeka S Dashboard



Navigation

Adding Items

- Under the “Items” tab, click “Add an item”
  - You can upload multiple files for one item
  - You can choose whether to make an item public or not
  - You item Values, optionally Media
  - You can edit items once they are added
- Then, add metadata!



Adding Metadata



- Dublin Core vs. Item Type Metadata
  - Dublin Core is the basic information that will be relevant **across items**
  - Item Type Metadata is additional information that is likely to be **relevant for specific item types** (e.g. duration for moving images, or subject line for emails)
- You can add additional input fields (for both types of metadata)
- Formatting text in metadata fields
  - If you click "Use HTML" you will get more formatting options
  - You can also enter basic HTML to make formatting edits that are not available in the default editor; for more information on the HTML editor, visit Omeka's guide to HTML editing.

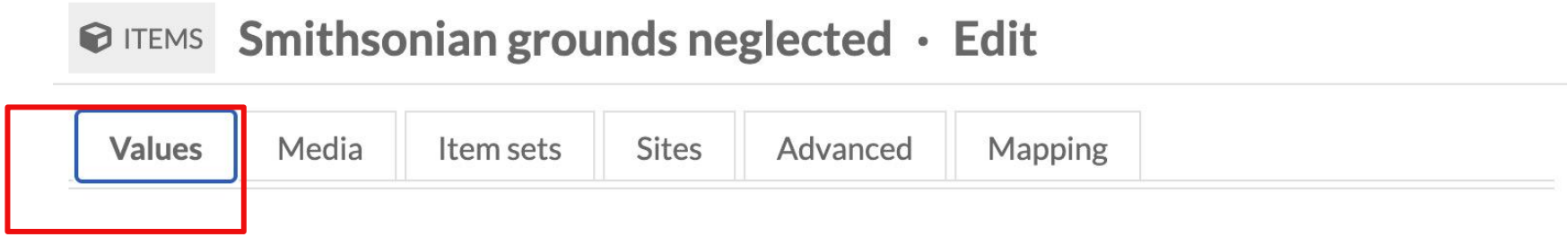
Adding Media to Items

- You can add multiple files to an item
- If you have more than one file, you can drag the order of files to change which one appears as the key image

File-Specific Metadata (1/2)

- You can add metadata for the **files** that you attach to your **items**
  - In this instance, the item is the Boston Dispensary building, and the file attached to the item is the image of it
- **File metadata does not appear automatically.** Once you upload an image, you need to click “edit” to get to the metadata.
- Example on following slide,

File-Specific Metadata



File-specific metadata

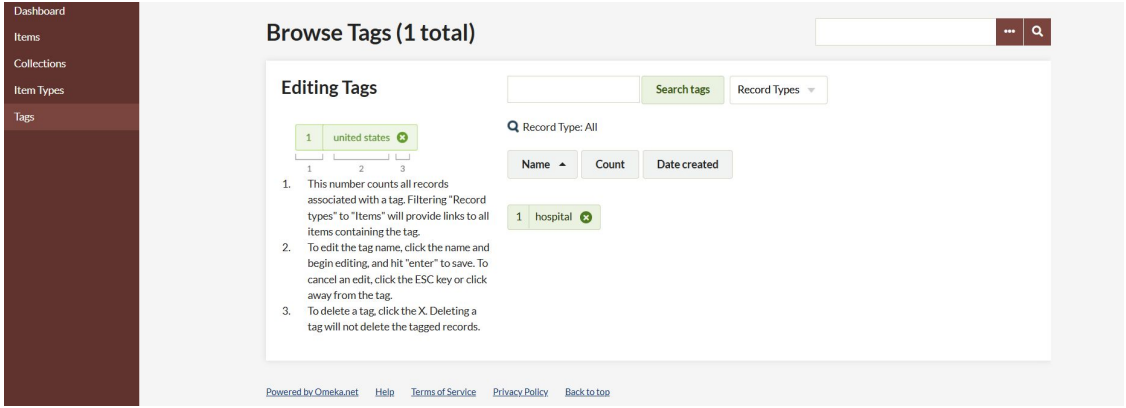
Organizing Items: Tags and Collections

- Items can have **multiple** tags, but they can only have **one** collection
- Origin: Tagging is more of a web-focused approach to managing information, whereas collections are from physical archiving, where every item is in a single collection



Adding and Editing Tags

- You **tag items** through editing an item
- You **edit tags** through the “tags” tab



Editing tags



Adding a tag to an item

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Editing Tags, continued

Make sure your tags are consistent!



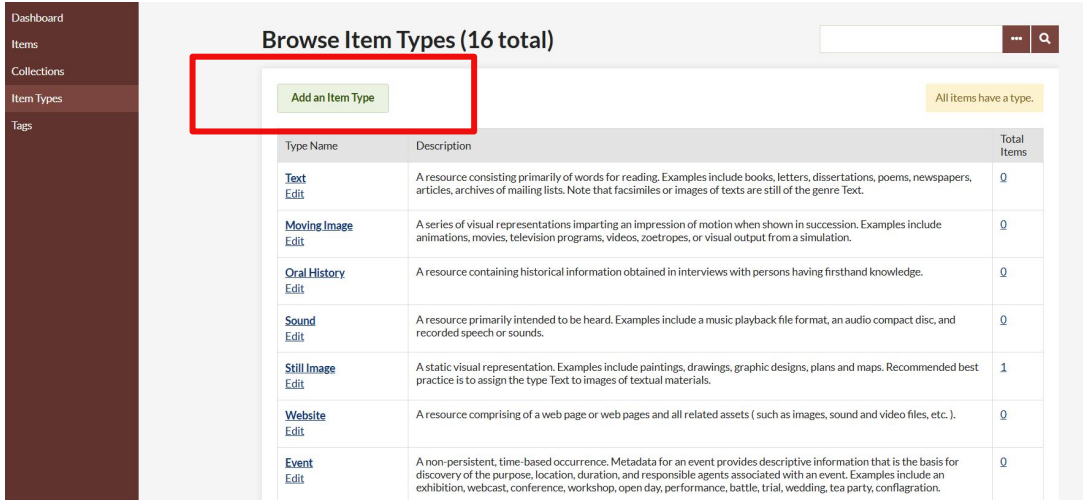
Adding Item Sets

Go to “Item Sets” and “Add new item sets”:

- the Title
- icons to edit (pencil), delete (trash can), or details (ellipsis)
- the item set's Class
- the Owner of the set
- the date the set was Created. An item set's linked resources are other Omeka resources (items, item sets, or media) that are linked to this item set through their properties. Choosing an Omeka resource as a metadata value creates an internal link between the resource you are creating and the resource that fills that field.

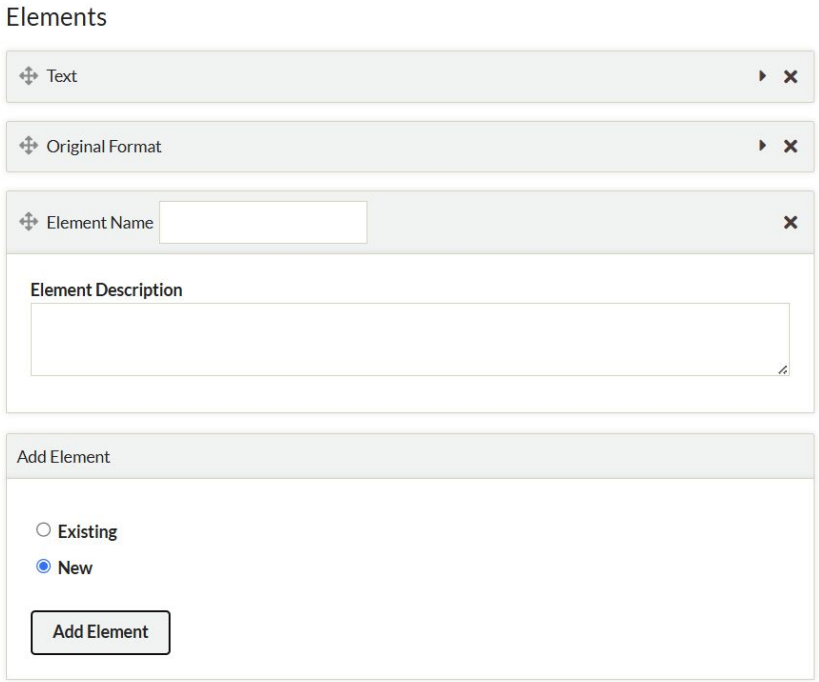
Item Types

- **Item types** are the different categorizations you can assign to an item. These include text, still image, person, email, etc.
- You can edit item types by clicking on “edit,” under the Item Types tab.
- There, you can edit the **description** of an item type and its elements.
- **Elements** are the different attributes of an item type.



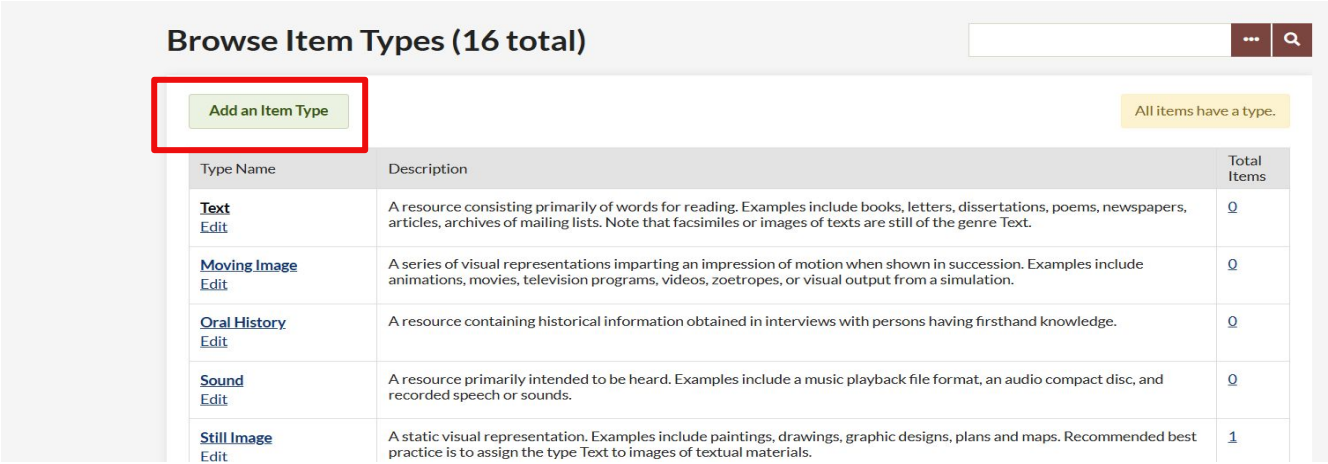
Editing Elements for Item Types

- You can add **existing elements** from a list or **create new ones**
- You can also remove the default elements for an item type (but make sure you think carefully before doing this!)



Adding New Item Types

You can add completely new item types by clicking the “Add an Item Type” button, giving the new item type a name and description, and adding elements to it (either existing or new).



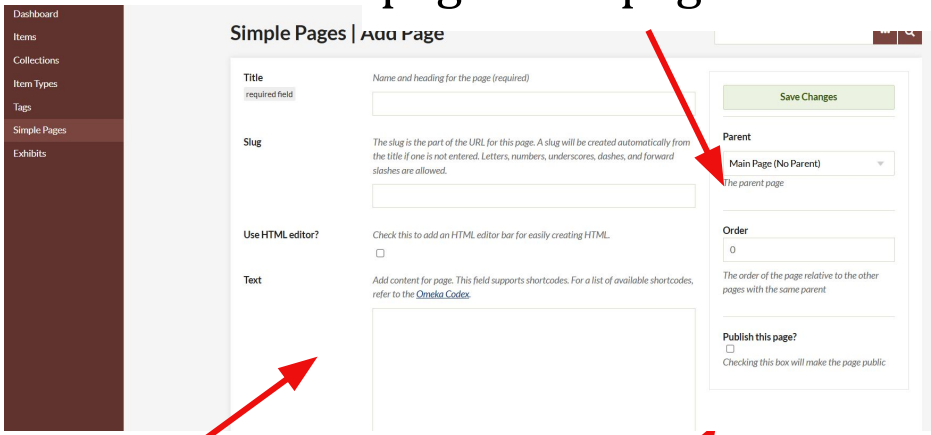
Modules

- Modules extend the functionality of your Omeka S installation and sites. A list of modules available for download is on the Modules Directory. Instructions are available on each module's documentation page.

Creating Simple Pages (1/2)

- **Simple pages** allow you to create web pages for your digital archive
- To add a page, click “Add a Page” under the “Simple Pages” tab. You can then add a title and edit the slug, or page URL

Establish navigation by designating parent pages and page order



This shortcode indicates that we want all items in Collection 1 to be included on this page

You can choose whether to make the page public

Creating Simple Pages (2/2)

- You choose items for your page by entering **Omeka shortcodes** into the text box (you can also use the text box just for text). A complete list of shortcodes can be found on the Omeka website, but useful ones include:
  - [items collection=1]
  - [items item_type="still image"]
  - [items tags=commercial,educational]

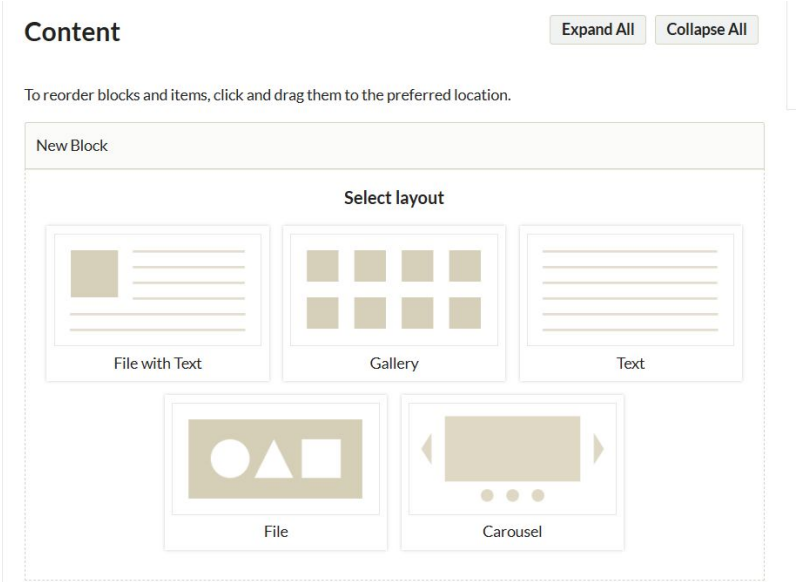
Site Pages

We will follow the guidelines on this link

https://omeka.org/s/docs/user-manual/sites/site_pages/

Exhibit Pages

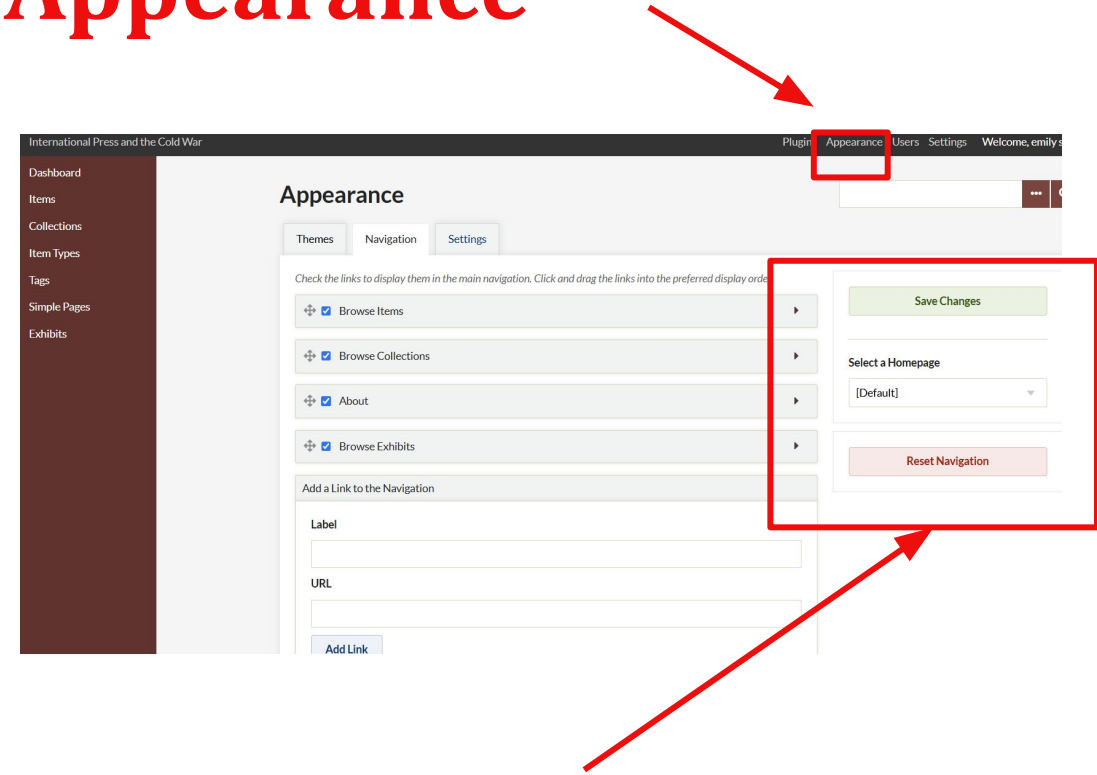
- The contents of exhibit pages are organized by **blocks**
- Layout options for blocks are: file with text, gallery, text, file, and carousel.
- Once you choose your layout option for a block, you can select the items to include
- Although some of the layout options display thumbnail images, you are curating the **item, not the attached file(s),** in your exhibit



Themes and Site Appearance

Under the Appearance tab in the top menu:

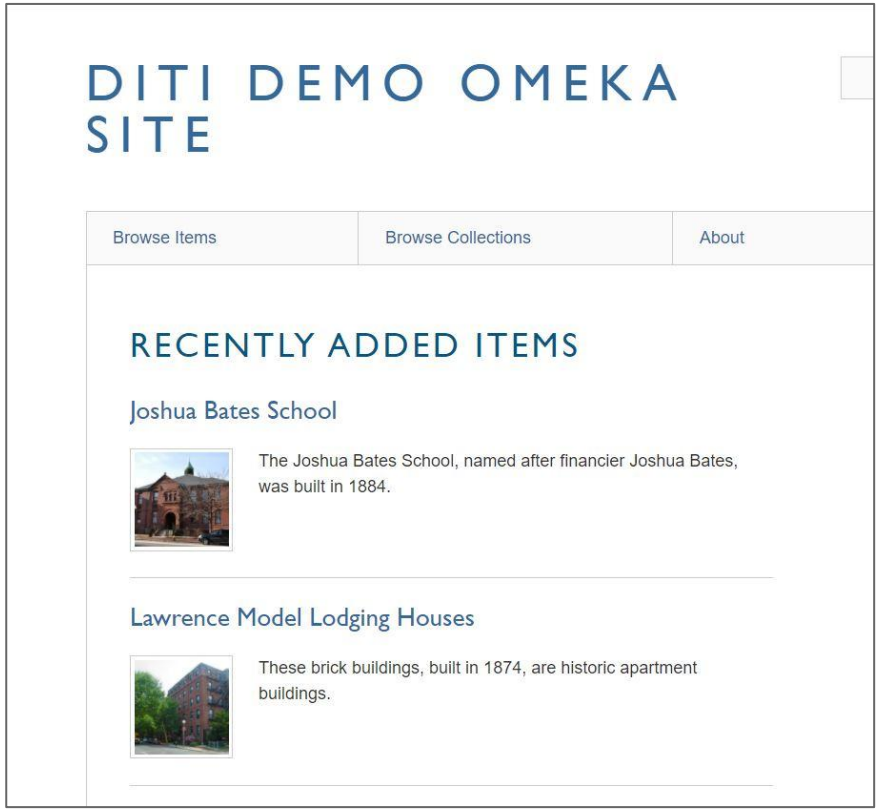
- “Themes” allows you to choose a visual theme
- “Navigation” allows you to control the main menu bar
- “Settings” offers some display choices, including how metadata appears and how thumbnails work



The default homepage is recent items but you can change this

Demo

- *Boston from End to End: NHRP sites in Boston's North and South Ends*
- Note: this is a demo of Omeka basics, not an actual archive project!



Omeka + Archival Project Best Practices

Website Hosting

- Paid versions of Omeka include **hosting** and support of maintenance on the CDS servers.
- **Omeka.net** includes a free “trial” account to build a single page with limited themes and plugins, but uses the same code as Omeka Classic; trial Omeka sites can be kept active indefinitely, there's no time limit.
- Hosting is important because it is integral to site sustainability, maintenance, domain URL, project identity.
- **Reclaim Hosting** is an organization used by many academics for web hosting with domain registration. They offer lower-cost hosting plans and provide helpful customer services and support.

Data Privacy and Maintenance on Omeka

- Omeka Services collects certain data about you, site visitors, and digital content stored on their platform. It is good practice to review the Omeka privacy policy to know how this data is used, stored, and managed.
- Omeka is *not* meant for long-term preservation without maintenance. Curators are responsible for updating materials on Omeka following version upgrades.

Digital Accessibility

- Omeka Classic includes accessibility features for both the front end and back end. See their Accessibility Statement for more details.
- Externally-developed themes and digital content may not be accessible for assistive tech users. Review the accessibility of your digital archive to make sure users can access archived materials.
- See the DITI Handout on Accessibility in Digital Content for more resources and tips.

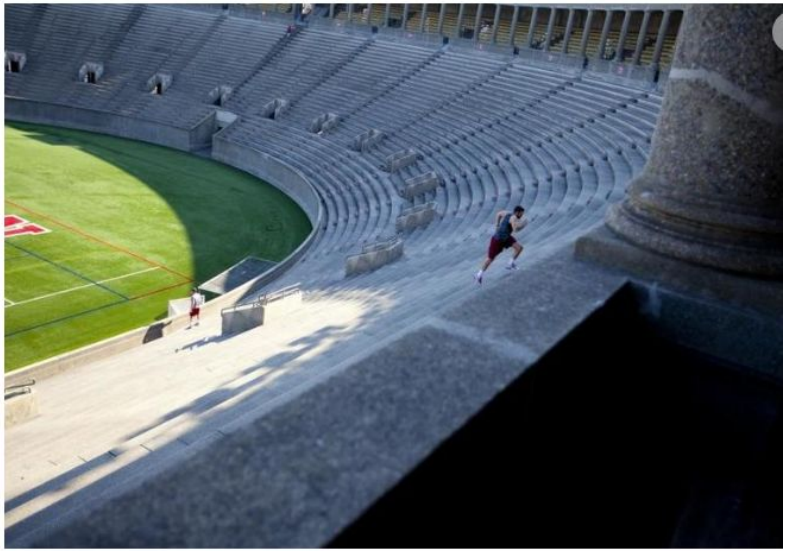
Adding alt text (part 1)

- Alt text is a description of an image that conveys the image content, meaning, and context. This descriptive text is attached to the image file metadata. For more information see the Northeastern Library Guidelines for alt text.
- People with low or no vision can use assistive technology like screen readers to hear the alt text description of digital images. When a screen reader reaches the image, it will read aloud the alt text description.

Adding alt text (part 2)

- Fill in the Title or Description field when you add an image, sound, or video file.
- Write a description of the image. For audio and video files, write a transcript of what is said, as well as describe the content, context, and purpose of the audio or video file.
- Check out the example to the right, created by Harvard University.

Example of Alt Text with Various Contexts



Alt-text with no context:

A mostly empty stadium.

Alt-text on a page about recent turnout for track tryouts:

Harvard Stadium with two lone runners bounding up the steps.

Alt-text on page about renovation projects:

Harvard Stadium with cracked concrete pillars.

Your Turn!

Set up your subdomain and Omeka site for your account. Then, try the following:

- Adding 2 or 3 items
- Creating an Item Set and adding items to an Item Set
- Site Page - add a page and customize it

Thank you!

Developed by: Claire Lavarreda, Juniper Johnson, Dipa Desai, Talia Brenner, Adam Tomasi, Sarah Connell, Patrick Murray-John, Kasya O'Connor Grant, Sara Morrell, Sayyara Poliferno, and Tiffany Cruz.

- For more details information see: Omeka S User Manual
- For more information on DITI, please see: https://bit.ly/diti-about
- Schedule an appointment with us! https://bit.ly/diti-meeting
- If you have any questions, contact us at: nulab.info@gmail.com

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